

Bible that existed at that point. He evidently recognized the Canon of 39 books that had been defined by His time. He cited a number of books—taken from the Law, history, prophecy and poetry—and He did so as being God’s Word, something true, holy and authoritative. The human authors of the NT demonstrated the same respect for the OT, which was their Bible as well.

I have said that the OT contains 39 books, and so it was until the sixteenth century of the Christian era. The Council of Trent was a reaction of the Roman Catholic Church against the Protestant Reformation. It started in 1545 and concluded its work in 1563. It added fourteen ‘books’ to the OT, although the fourteen had never been recognized by the Hebrew community. In Protestant circles, those books are generally referred to as the ‘Apocrypha’, while in Roman Catholic circles they are referred to as being ‘Deutero-canonical’. The Canon of the NT was formally closed by the Council of Carthage in 397 AD, the Canon of the OT having been closed centuries earlier. Surely 1563 was altogether too late to be adding books to the Sacred Text.¹

Now then, canonization has everything to do with the preservation of the Text. Surely, because the community of the Faith would only concern itself to transmit and protect the ‘canonical’ books, those that were held to be inspired.² When I take up the question of preservation, below, I will argue that it is precisely the preservation of the Text that proves its

¹ 1 Maccabees (c. 175-135 BC) makes no claim to be Scripture and indeed claims to be written after the age of the prophets (see 9:27; 4:46; 14:41). 1 Macc. 9:27 acknowledges that the succession of Old Testament prophets had already ceased. 1 Macc. 4:46 says that Israel was waiting till the Messiah when a prophet might arise to tell them what to do with the heap of stones. Apparently no prophet was in existence at the time of the writing. The absence of prophets can be seen in 1 Macc. 14:41; 2 Esdras 14:45; etc. Thus, in the Prologue to Sirach, the grandson makes clear that ben Sirach was simply a wise man and he was simply translating. See the apology of the author in 2 Macc. 15:38—“And if I have done well, and as is fitting the story, it is that which I desired: but if slenderly and meanly, it is that which I could attain unto.” A prophet would speak with authority, not apologize for how poorly he wrote. [I owe this information to Dr. Phillip Kayser.]

² For example, there are those who argue that the Autograph of Matthew was written in Hebrew. But there is a small difficulty with that thesis: there is not even one known copy of that Gospel in Hebrew. Since it was only the Greek Matthew that the Church protected and transmitted, then the autograph was written in Greek, obviously. However, it seems to me to be equally obvious that Matthew, and anyone else who could write, filled ‘note-books’ with his annotations of what Jesus said and did. Yes, because Luke 1:1 states that “many have undertaken to set in order a narrative concerning those things”. All notes taken on the spot would have to be in Hebrew, because that was the language Jesus used. As Matthew wrote his Gospel in Greek, he certainly consulted his notes written in Hebrew. The lack of even one Greek copy of such things as the gospel of Thomas, or Judas, or whatever, indicates that they were not inspired and were not recognized by the Church.